GUJARATI COLLECTION

NO. 03



GUJARAT ORIGIN

Gujarati Dal

Sweet, Tangy & Spiced Toor Dal
The Soul of a Gujarati Thali

AUTHENTIC RECIPE · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE · PRINTABLE DIGITAL COOKBOOK

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

LICENSE & COPYRIGHT NOTICE

Gujarati Dal

Sold via: Gumroad
Publisher: DhanioDigital (dhaniodigital.gumroad.com)

PERSONAL USE LICENSE

This digital cookbook is licensed for personal, non-commercial use only.
You may print one (1) copy for your own kitchen use.

YOU MAY NOT:

- Share, resell, or redistribute this file in any form
- Upload to any website, cloud service, or file-sharing platform
- Remove or obscure any watermarks, copyright notices, or branding
- Use recipes for commercial food service without written permission

Violation of this license may result in legal action.

© 2024 DhanioDigital. All rights reserved.
Contact: support@dhaniodigital.com

ABOUT THIS BOOK

Gujarati Dal

AUTHOR

Sweta Verma

PUBLISHER

DhanioDigital

COPYRIGHT

© 2026 Sweta Verma. All rights reserved. No part of this publication may be reproduced or distributed without written permission from the publisher.

DISCLAIMER

Nutrition values are estimates. Cooking times vary with equipment and ingredients. Readers with allergies or dietary restrictions should check every ingredient label before cooking.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Where Sweet Meets Sour Meets Spice

If there's one dish that captures the distinctive character of Gujarati cuisine — its comfort with balancing sweetness against tang and spice in ways many other Indian regional cuisines don't attempt — it's Gujarati dal. Built from toor dal (split pigeon pea) like countless other Indian dals, what sets this version apart is a deliberate three-way balance of jaggery for sweetness, kokum or lemon for tang, and green chili and whole spices for heat, all present simultaneously rather than one flavor dominating.

This sweet-tangy-spicy signature reflects a broader pattern across Gujarati cooking, visible in dishes throughout this collection, and food historians and Gujaratis themselves often trace this preference partly to the state's historical role as a major trading hub, with centuries of exposure to imported spices, sugar, and diverse culinary influences from across the Indian Ocean trade routes shaping local taste in distinctive ways.

Gujarati dal is served at nearly every Gujarati meal, forming an essential component of the traditional Gujarati thali alongside rice, roti, shaak (vegetable curry), and kathol (bean curry) — a foundational, everyday dish that nonetheless carries genuine complexity in its carefully balanced flavor.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

THE STORY BEHIND THE DISH

Where Sweet Meets Sour Meets Spice, continued

CULTURAL NOTES & OCCASIONS

An essential, near-daily component of the traditional Gujarati thali, served alongside rice, roti, and vegetable dishes. Exemplifies Gujarati cuisine's distinctive comfort with balancing sweet, tangy, and spicy flavors simultaneously, a hallmark of the region's cooking. Sometimes connected by food historians to Gujarat's historical role as a major Indian Ocean trading hub, with centuries of exposure to imported sugar and spices. A dish so fundamental to Gujarati identity that its specific sweet-tangy balance is often the first thing people mention when discussing the difference between Gujarati and other regional Indian cuisines.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

AT A GLANCE

Equipment & preparation

10m	30m	4	Easy
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME	SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

Recommended equipment

- Pressure cooker
- Kadai or pan, for the tempering
- Whisk, for smoothing the dal

STORAGE & MAKE-AHEAD

Gujarati dal keeps refrigerated for up to 4 days and reheats well with a splash of water to loosen the consistency. It freezes well for up to 2 months, making it a practical make-ahead staple for busy weeks.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients

For the dal

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Toor dal (split pigeon pea)	1 cup	200 g	1 katori
Water, for cooking	3 cups	720 ml	3 katori
Turmeric powder	½ tsp	1.5 g	½ chammach
Salt	¾ tsp	4.5 g	to taste

For the tempering & seasoning

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Ghee or oil	2 tbsp	30 g	2 chammach
Mustard seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Cumin seeds	1 tsp	4 g	1 chammach
Asafoetida (hing)	pinch	pinch	chutki bhar
Curry leaves	1 sprig	8–10 leaves	1 sprig
Dried red chili	1–2	1–2	1–2
Cinnamon stick	1 inch	1 inch	1 inch
Cloves	2	2	2
Ginger, minced	1 tbsp	10 g	1 chammach
Green chili, slit	1–2	1–2	1–2

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Ingredients, continued

For the tempering & seasoning (cont.)

INGREDIENT	US	METRIC	INDIAN
Raw peanuts	2 tbsp	20 g	2 tbsp
Jaggery, grated	2 tbsp	25 g	2 tbsp
Kokum pieces or lemon juice	3–4 pieces or 2 tbsp	3–4 pieces or 30 ml	3–4 pieces or 2 chammach
Fresh coriander, chopped, for garnish	2 tbsp	8 g	2 tbsp

SUBSTITUTIONS & SOURCING

Kokum, a dried, tangy fruit specific to Western Indian cooking, can be found at Indian grocers; if unavailable, lemon juice or tamarind paste both approximate its distinctive sour note reasonably well. Jaggery is the traditional sweetener; light brown sugar is a fine substitute if jaggery isn't available. Raw peanuts add a pleasant textural bite; roasted, unsalted peanuts also work if raw aren't easy to source.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cooking the Dal

01 RINSE AND PRESSURE COOK

Rinse the toor dal and pressure cook with water, turmeric, and salt for 4–5 whistles, until completely soft.

02 WHISK SMOOTH

Once cooked, whisk the dal smooth, adding a little extra water if needed to reach a pourable, medium-thin consistency — Gujarati dal is traditionally thinner than many other regional dals.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART ONE

Cooking the Dal, continued

Chef tip. Gujarati dal's thinner consistency, compared to thicker North Indian dals, is intentional — resist the urge to reduce it too much.

COOKING CHECKPOINT

The dal should be completely smooth with no visible lentil chunks, and thin enough to pour easily — closer to a soup than a thick stew.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

STEP BY STEP · PART TWO

The Sweet-Tangy-Spicy Balance

03 BUILD THE TEMPERING

Heat ghee in a kadai. Add mustard seeds, letting them pop, then cumin seeds, asafoetida, curry leaves, dried red chili, cinnamon, and cloves, letting everything sizzle until fragrant.

04 ADD GINGER, CHILI, AND PEANUTS

Add the minced ginger, green chili, and peanuts, cooking for 1–2 minutes until the peanuts turn lightly golden.



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

The Sweet-Tangy-Spicy Balance, continued

05 COMBINE WITH THE DAL

Pour the tempering into the smooth dal, stirring to combine. Add the jaggery and kokum (or lemon juice), and simmer for 10–12 minutes, letting the sweet, tangy, and spicy elements meld together.

Cooking checkpoint. taste and adjust — the finished dal should have a clear but balanced presence of sweetness, tang, and mild heat, with no single note overwhelming the others.

06 GARNISH AND SERVE

Finish with a scatter of fresh coriander just before serving.

MISTAKE TO AVOID

Adding too much jaggery without balancing it against the kokum or lemon results in a dal that tastes cloying rather than complex. Add sweetener and sour agent gradually, tasting as you go, to find the right balance for your palate.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve



Traditional Style

- Served as part of a full Gujarati thali, alongside rice, roti, shaak, and kathol.
- Poured over steamed rice with a spoon of ghee for a simple, comforting standalone meal.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

SERVING & PAIRING

How to serve, continued

Restaurant Presentation

- Served in a small bowl or katori as part of a thali platter, garnished with coriander.

Family Style

- A shared pot at the center of the table, ladled fresh over rice for each family member.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

RESTAURANT-GRADE TRICKS

Chef secrets

Getting the Balance Right

- Taste as you build the sweet-tangy-spicy balance rather than following exact quantities blindly — personal preference varies significantly even within Gujarati households.
- Kokum gives a more traditional, slightly fruity tang compared to lemon juice — worth seeking out if you want the most authentic flavor.

Make-Ahead & Meal Prep

- Gujarati dal reheats very well, making it a practical make-ahead component of a larger thali meal.
- Cook a big batch of dal without the tempering, then finish smaller portions with fresh tempering as needed throughout the week.

RESTAURANT TRICK

Some Gujarati restaurants finish the dal with a small piece of butter stirred in right before serving for extra richness — a modern touch not strictly traditional but widely enjoyed.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ

APPROXIMATE NUTRITION, PER SERVING

165 kcal	8 g	22 g	5 g	6 g
CALORIES	PROTEIN	CARBOHYDRATES	FAT	FIBER

Estimates only; actual values vary with oil and portion size.

ALLERGEN GUIDE

Contains, based on the ingredient list: Dairy, Gluten, Peanuts, Mustard. Check packaged spices and asafoetida, which may contain wheat, and verify against your own ingredients.

REGIONAL VARIATIONS

Kathiyawadi Dal	a spicier, less sweet version from the Kathiawad region of Gujarat.
Surti Dal	a milder, sweeter version associated with the Surat region.
Dal with Vegetables	some households add a handful of chopped vegetables like drumstick or eggplant for extra heartiness.

Why is Gujarati dal thinner than other dals?

This is an intentional regional characteristic — Gujarati dal is traditionally served thin and soupy, distinct from the thicker consistency common in North Indian dals.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

BONUS CONTENT

Nutrition, variations & FAQ, continued

Can I make this without jaggery?

Light brown sugar works as a substitute, though jaggery's more complex, slightly smoky sweetness is traditional and worth seeking out.

What is kokum, and can I skip it?

Kokum is a dried, tangy Western Indian fruit; lemon juice or tamarind are good substitutes if it's unavailable, though kokum gives the most traditional flavor.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary



© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

REFERENCE

Ingredient glossary, continued

GLOSSARY

Kokum	a dried, tangy fruit native to Western India, used for sour notes in Gujarati cooking.
Kathol	Gujarati for a bean or legume curry, a component of a traditional thali alongside dal.
Thali	a complete Indian meal served on a platter with multiple small dishes.
Gol	Gujarati for jaggery, essential to the sweet element of this dish.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

PRINTABLE RECIPE CARD

Gujarati Dal

10m	30m
ACTIVE PREP	COOK TIME
4	**Easy**
SERVINGS	DIFFICULTY

DAL

Toor dal	200 g
Water	720 ml
Turmeric powder	1.5 g
Salt	4.5 g

TEMPERING & SEASONING

Ghee or oil	30 g
Mustard seeds	4 g
Cumin seeds	4 g
Asafoetida	pinch
Curry leaves	8–10 leaves
Dried red chili	1–2
Cinnamon stick	1 inch
Cloves	2
Ginger	10 g
Green chili	1–2
Raw peanuts	20 g
Jaggery	25 g
Kokum pieces or lemon juice	3–4 pieces or 30 ml
Fresh coriander	8 g

METHOD

01 **Rinse and pressure cook.** Rinse the toor dal and pressure cook with water, turmeric, and salt for 4–5 whistles, until completely soft.

02 **Whisk smooth.** Once cooked, whisk the dal smooth, adding a little extra water if needed to reach a pourable, medium-thin consistency — Gujarati dal is traditionally thinner than many other regional dals.

03 **Build the tempering.** Heat ghee in a kadai.

04 **Add ginger, chili, and peanuts.** Add the minced ginger, green chili, and peanuts, cooking for 1–2 minutes until the peanuts turn lightly golden.

05 **Combine with the dal.** Pour the tempering into the smooth dal, stirring to combine.

06 **Garnish and serve.** Finish with a scatter of fresh coriander just before serving.

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com

BEFORE YOU SHOP

Shopping list

☐	Toor dal	200 g	
☐	Salt	4.5 g	
☐	Mustard seeds	4 g	
☐	Asafoetida	pinch	
☐	Dried red chili	1–2	
☐	Cloves	2	
☐	Green chili	1–2	
☐	Jaggery	25 g	
☐	Fresh coriander	8 g	
☐	Turmeric powder	1.5 g	
☐	Ghee or oil	30 g	
☐	Cumin seeds	4 g	
☐	Curry leaves	8–10 leaves	
☐	Cinnamon stick	1 inch	
☐	Ginger	10 g	
☐	Raw peanuts	20 g	
☐	Kokum pieces or lemon juice	3–4 pieces or 30 ml	

© DhanioDigital · Personal use only · Not for redistribution · dhaniodigital.gumroad.com